

Deep Dive: Finding the Right Fit

Sue Nokes

So, Pat always said to own your game. And that's very, very true, and I don't disagree with her, obviously. But your game has to fit in the broader team.

Charles Barkley taught me about “fit.” Charles, when I worked at T Mobile, Charles and I had an opportunity to work several times together and he was harassing me one day, and I looked at him and I said, well, what about you and all that money you spent to get a title before you left the NBA?

And Charles had given up like 10 million dollars of his own money to go get the final piece because they were trying to get him an NBA title before he hung up his sneakers. And he did, and he went and got a big-name guy who I won't mention, but I said, so how did that spin go for you, buddy? Where's that ring?

And he looked at me and he said, I didn't know. He couldn't play without so-and-so. And the deal is, do you fit in the system? You see it all the time in sports that one team will purchase a great reliever pitcher and send them to another team and they don't turn out to do as well in their new home. It's about fit, and fit is important for you to be and own your own game.

When you go look for jobs and you're assessing where you want to go or where your next job is going to be or what your next move is going to be, what's very important is – yep -- you need to know the official rules and regulations and what are their aspirations and what are their values and how do they say they want to run the joint. But there's always an unofficial set of rules.

And what you have to figure out is, “Is it a good fit for me?” Because if it's not a good fit for me, I will never be all I can be in that environment, and I will never give them the best I can be in their environment. This was made very clear to me early on in my career when I was offered a COO job and a major healthcare company.

And at the time I was an SVP, and I thought, “Oh my.” You know, women, glass ceilings. And for me, it was always about making a difference. Could I go someplace and make a difference? Would they know that I've been there? And so, I thought, “Well, healthcare. Who loves their healthcare provider?” So, here I go, and I go for the interview.

I interviewed with the CEO. And the CEO was new to that role. And I came back, got my feedback, and my feedback was, “They love you. They like you, et cetera, et cetera. When can you go?”

And my answer was, “I can't.” Because I knew that that CEO and my values were not in harmony. That we would cause each other to stroke within the next 12-18 months.

Because my focus was more on the customer and the frontline employee and theirs was not. Doesn't make that CEO wrong and me right, but it does alter where you will be more effective. So, I always tell people, don't chase the title. Don't try to take a job to just get your foot in the door. Really look around and say, “Do I fit?”

One of the things that I found is most effective -- the most effective tool for a leader and your career is a mirror, because when things aren't going well, you need to pick it up and kind of look at it and say, “What is it that I know about myself that I'm not using, or what is it that I know about myself that I'm suppressing?”

Because it's not everybody else. It's about 80/20 proposition. 80 percent of your career is your responsibility. What job is it you want? Have you told anybody you want it? But at first, when you'd ask women what they want to be when they grow up, they may sometimes say, “Well, you know, I might be able to be...” and it would be the next level in the organization, because you didn't want to seem too aggressive and all those other negative words that come along with knowing what you want.

Today, I have those conversations with women that say, “Well, I'm going to be a COO and if it's not here, it'll be someplace else.”

I like it. Because it's okay to know what you want. And what are you willing to do that's not illegal, immoral, or indecent? And what are your values? And how are you going to use and maximize the skills you have and build a team that gets you where you want, and everybody can come with you.

If you build the right team and you give them the proper training and tools and information, they need to do their job, and you are aligned around a goal...There is no better example than Pat Summit.

So, when you go into that organization, again, profit, for-profit, non-profit, academia. What is it that you're aspiring to? And have you communicated that vision and are you all aligned on the goals? And this is what, what we're going to achieve together. And here are the rules by which we're going to play together. And when you're not, you hold each other accountable to that and amazing things can happen. But you got to know where you're going.

Because good old Alice in Wonderland says, “If you don't know where you're going, any road will take you there.”

It's about, do you fit? And can you be you as a part of that team and be your true self and give it all you got.